A Manhattan Romance

By Joyce Carol Oates

(Pg 209-220) That wild day! I'd woken before it was even dawn; I seemed to know that a terrible happiness was in store. I was five years old [and] feverish with excitement when Daddy came to pick me up for our ***Saturday adventure*** as he called it.

MOMMA: *(whispering)* If you said you were sick, you wouldn't have to go with – him.

For she could not utter the word ***Daddy***, and even the words ***your father*** made her mouth twist. *(to Momma)* Momma, I'm not sick! I'm not! *(to audience)* So the doorman sent Daddy up.

MOMMA: I wish you didn't have to leave me, darling, but it's the terms of the agreement- it's the law.

These bitter words ***It's the law*** fell from Momma's lips each Saturday morning. And then Momma leaned over me and kissed me; I loved Momma's perfume and her soft-shining hair but I wanted to push away from her; I wanted

4NG Fanatics

to run to the door, to surprise Daddy, who took such happiness in being surprised; I wanted to say to Momma, ***I love Daddy better than I love you, let me go!*** Because Momma was Momma, but Daddy – there would never be a man so handsome and radiant as Daddy.

INTRODUCTION

Divorce is a highly stressful and emotional experience for everyone involved, but children often feel that their whole world has turned upside down. Custody battles, child support and visitation rights are terms that no small child can fully understand.

And for a father with limited visitation rights, a stressor that may become too much to bear.

Manhattan Romance by Joyce Carol Oates

Our driver that day was an Asian man in a neat dark uniform and gloves. Daddy no longer drove his own car. His enemies had taken his driver's license to humiliate him, he said. They could not defeat him in any way that mattered, for he was too strong for them and too smart.

Other Saturdays, we'd gone to Radio City Music Hall, we'd seen Beauty and the Beast on Broadway; we'd seen the Big Apple Circus at Lincoln Center. Daddy liked me to

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

smile and laugh, not to worry; not ever, ever to cry. He'd had it up to here *(drawing a forefinger across her throat, like a knife blade)* with crying, he said.

DADDY: Today, Princess, we'll buy presents. That's what we'll do -- "store up riches."

Christmas presents? I asked.

DADDY: Sure. Christmas presents, any kind of presents. For you, and for me. Because we're special. *(smiling)* You know we are special, Princess, don't you? And all your life you'll remember your Daddy loves you? -- That's the one true thing.

Yes Daddy, I said. For of course it was so.

Daddy bought me a dark blue velvet coach, a beautiful silk scarf and a white-gold wrist watch studded with tiny emeralds. For all these wonderful presents, Daddy paid in cash. I knew it was strange for Daddy to be paying out of thick-stuffed envelopes in his inside coat pockets. No one else paid in such a way. [But, he] no longer used credit cards, he said he refused to be a cog in the network of

4NG Fanatics

government surveillance, he said; they would not catch him in their net; he would not play their ridiculous games.

Next, we went to the Museum of Modern Art, where Daddy lifted me to his shoulders and carried me into a large, airy room. There were tears in Daddy's eyes as he held me in his arms -- his arms that trembled slightly – to gaze at an enormous paintings -- several paintings -- broad beautiful dreamy-blue paintings of a pond and water lilies; Daddy told me that these paintings were by a very great artist named "Mon-ay" and that there was magic in them; he told me that these paintings made him comprehend his own soul, or what his soul had been meant to be; for as soon as you left the presence of such beauty, you devoured by the crowd.

When we left the museum, I was dazed with exhaustion. I could not have said how long Daddy and I had been shopping, on our Saturday adventure; yet I loved it, that strangers observed us, and remarked how pretty I was; and to Daddy sometimes they would say, ***Your face is familiar, are you on TV?*** But Daddy just laughed and kept moving, for there was no time to spare that day.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Years later I would learn that, that afternoon, a warrant for Daddy's arrest had been issued by the Manhattan district attorney's office; by some of the very people for whom, until a few months ago, Daddy had worked. It would be charged against him that as a prosecuting attorney, Daddy had misused the powers of his office and blackmailed others, embezzled funds, and committed perjury. . . such charges were made against Daddy, such lies concocted by his enemies who had been jealous of him for years and wanted him destroyed. One day I would learn that New York City police detectives had come to Daddy's apartment to arrest him but hadn't found him. Momma told them that Daddy would be bringing me back home at 5:30 pm, or in any case he'd promised to do so; if they waited for him in the lobby downstairs would they please please not arrest him in front of his daughter. And now an alert was out in Manhattan for Daddy, he was a "wanted" man.

So exhausted! Daddy scolded me, carrying me into the lobby of the Hotel Pierre, [where he] booked a suite for us on the sixteenth floor. You could look from a window to

4NG Fanatics

see the apartment building on Central Park South where Momma and I lived. Once we were inside the suite Daddy bolted the door and slid the chain lock in place. There were two TVs and Daddy turned them both on. He turned on the ventilator fans in all the rooms. He took the telephone receivers off their hooks.

DADDY: *(breathing hard, eyes rapidly shifting)* Princess! Get up please. Don't disappoint your Daddy.

Daddy found a can of apple juice in the mini bar, poured it into a glass and added something from another little bottle.

DADDY: Princess, this is a magic potion. Drink!

And so I did. A hot hurting sensation spread in my mouth and I started to choke. Daddy pressed the palm of his hand over my mouth to quiet me. I was sickish now and I was frightened; but I was happy, too; I was drunk with happiness from all we'd done that day, Daddy and me. I had never had so many presents before. I had never understood how special I was before and afterward when they asked me if I'd been afraid of my Daddy I would say

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

no! No, I hadn't been! Not for a minute! I love my Daddy I would say, and my Daddy loves me.

[I heard] pounding at the door. And men's voices calling . . .

POLICE: Police! Open up Mr. _____"

. . . saying Daddy's name as I'd never heard it before. Daddy was excited and angry and he had a gun in his hand -- I knew it was a gun, I'd seen pictures of guns – and he was waving [it] as if the men on the other side of the door could see him. There was a film of sweat on his face. I had never seen my Daddy so furious calling to the policemen

DADDY: I've got my little girl here, my daughter -- and I've got a gun.

But they were pounding at the door; they were breaking down the door; Daddy fired the gun into the air and pulled me into another room.

DADDY: I'll use it, I'm not afraid – I'm not going to prison – I can't! I've got my little girl here, you understand?

Daddy pushed me down, panting. I was too scared to cry, [but] Daddy was crying. We were crouched in the

4NG Fanatics

farthest darkest corner of the room. The magic potion had made me sleepy and sickish; it was hard for me to stay awake.

POLICE: "Mr. _____, surrender your weapon, will you? Toss it where we can see it, will you?

Daddy's face was streaked with tears like something melting. And still the voice said, calmly, so loud it seemed to come from everywhere at once,

POLICE: Mr. _____, you're not a man to harm a little girl, we know you're a good man, you're not a man to harm anyone.

And suddenly Daddy said . . .

DADDY: Yes! Yes, that's right. *(to daughter in a high happy voice)* Princess, your Daddy loves you, that's one true thing. Never forget, that's the one true thing in your life of mostly lies. Good-bye, Princess!"

Daddy placed the barrel of the gun deep inside his mouth. And Daddy pulled the trigger.

So it ended. It always ends. But don't tell me there isn't happiness. It exists, it's there. You just have to find it,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

and you have to keep it, if you can. It won't last, but it's there.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Joyce Carol Oates
Book: Faithless: Tales of Transgression (Pg 209-220)
ISBN: 978-0060933579
Publisher: Perennial Press
Date (Month/Year): June 2002

AWARD HISTORY

IL State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY